

Parental Leave Policy

Policy code: POL-HR-031 | Owner: People Team | Effective date: 1 April 2023 | Version: 1

1. Purpose

Meridian Instruments wants employees to be able to spend time with their families when a child arrives. This policy sets a global minimum standard of company-enhanced parental pay, which applies on top of the statutory leave and pay rights in each country where we operate.

2. Scope

The policy covers birth parents, primary adopters, surrogate parents who are the child's intended primary carer, and partners (including the other adoptive parent). It applies to employees in the UK, the Netherlands, the United States and Malaysia.

Where local law gives a better entitlement than this policy, the local law applies. Where this policy is more generous, the company enhancement applies.

3. Eligibility

To receive company-enhanced pay, an employee must have at least 26 weeks of continuous service with Meridian at the 15th week before the expected week of childbirth, or at the week the adopter is notified of being matched with a child. Employees who do not meet the service requirement still receive their full statutory leave and pay.

4. Birth parent and primary adopter leave

Eligible birth parents and primary adopters receive 16 weeks at full pay. After the enhanced period, the remainder of any statutory leave is paid at the statutory rate for the country, and any further unpaid statutory leave may be taken.

Country | Statutory leave (summary) | Company enhancement

UK | up to 52 weeks | 16 weeks full pay

Netherlands | 16 weeks pregnancy and maternity leave | 16 weeks full pay

United States | up to 12 weeks unpaid (FMLA) | 16 weeks full pay

Malaysia | 98 days maternity leave | 16 weeks full pay

Company pay is paid through normal payroll. Any statutory pay the employee receives, such as Statutory Maternity Pay in the UK or the UWV benefit in the Netherlands, is offset against company pay, so the employee receives no more than full pay in total.

5. Partner leave

Eligible partners receive 2 weeks of partner leave at full pay. The leave must be taken in one block or two separate weeks within 8 weeks of the birth or placement. Statutory partner leave beyond this is paid at the statutory rate where one applies.

6. Adoption and surrogacy

Primary adopters and intended primary carers through surrogacy receive the same entitlement as birth parents. Reasonable paid time off is given to attend adoption meetings and up to five antenatal appointments for the intended parents.

7. Notification

Employees must notify their manager and the People Team using the Parental Leave Notification (F-301) at least 15 weeks before the expected week of childbirth, or within 7 days of being matched for adoption. The form records the expected date, intended start of leave and any partner leave dates. Leave dates can be changed with 28 days' notice.

8. During leave

Contractual benefits other than salary continue during enhanced paid leave. Annual leave continues to accrue under the regional leave policy for your country. Employees may work up to 10 keeping-in-touch days by agreement with their manager, paid at their normal daily rate, without ending their leave.

Pension contributions continue during the enhanced paid period on the basis of full pay. During any statutory-paid or unpaid period, employer contributions follow the rules for your country's pension arrangement. Life cover and medical insurance continue throughout the whole period of leave.

Managers should agree with the employee before leave starts how much contact they would like during leave, and should make sure the employee continues to receive important announcements, such as changes to their team, restructures and internal vacancies.

9. Returning to work

Employees returning from birth parent or primary adopter leave may take a phased return of 4 weeks working 80% of their normal hours on full pay. The pattern is agreed with the line manager before the return date.

Employees who wish to change their working pattern permanently after leave can submit a Flexible Working Request (F-315).

10. Repayment

Company-enhanced pay is not subject to repayment if the employee does not return to work.

11. Contacts

Questions about this policy can be raised with peoplehelp@meridian-instruments.example. Payroll questions about statutory pay offsets should go to the payroll team for your country.